

Cart 263 Project I

Team member: Xueyi Xia(40333654), Weini Wang(40072313)

github live link : <https://bbwinnie.github.io/CART-263-PROJECT-I/>

github repositories link : <https://github.com/bbwinnie/CART-263-PROJECT-I.git>

Artist Statement

This program is about how digital media shapes the relationship between the self and society. This project centers on the core question of how digital media subtly shapes individual self-perception. In the beginning, I understood algorithms as technical tools, but after engaging with the course readings, I realized that algorithms are not neutral systems, they are organization mechanisms with structural power.

Inspired by Joans Lund's work "We See in Every Direction", I began thinking about how digital systems organize visibility. In this organization-controlled environment, individuals do not have complete freedom to express themselves. The entire process exists in a state of being watched. Visibility in digital spaces doesn't naturally exist; it is filtered, sequenced and distributed. Who becomes visible and who is recommended often depends on the underlying mechanisms.

In this organization structure, individuals unconsciously adjust their behaviour to maintain their visibility. For the sake of attention, recommendations and approval, we change the way we express ourselves. We may even construct a self-image that is suitable for being seen. This form of self-adjustment is not entirely voluntary; it is behavior shaped by organizational power. Through this process, digital systems organize not only content, but also our actions and identities. At the same time, we were also inspired by the concept of the "pluriverse," which refers to a world where multiple worlds coexist. Our question is: within an algorithmic structure dominated by a small number of technology companies can individuals still have pluralistic ways of existence?

At the early stage of creation, we originally hoped to conduct a collective browsing experiment, simulating a state where multiple people share the same digital space. However, during testing, we found that what truly attracted us was not sharing but watching. Therefore, the project gradually changed direction, shifting toward research on the structure of watching and being watched. Through the interactive web format, we continuously remind users during the browsing process that they are being recorded and that they are not independent individuals, but accounts within the system creating a sense of instability and loss of control.

In terms of form, we used basic DOM manipulation and CSS to build the interactive logic, avoiding complex frameworks. The interface itself shows a calm, even surveillance like visual style. The webpage data changes: twinkles, recurring text and automatic pulsation mean the algorithmic system's constant interference with the individual. Viewers gradually become aware during the interaction process that their own behaviour affects the system and is also led by the system.

In the creation process, the biggest challenge was how to find a balance between conceptual depth and experiential engagement. We didn't want the work to only stop at theoretical expression; we hoped the audience could, through an embodied browsing experience, feel the psychological pressure brought by the digital environment. At the same time, we were also faced with technical constraints, such as how to maintain a concise structure while making the arrangement of ideas rich and the interactive result meaningful.

Rather than offering a solution, this project is most like an awareness- arousing space. Through placing the audience within an audience and constantly responding system we try to make the organizational mechanisms of digital systems which are usually invisible temporarily perceptible. From this perspective this project is not only a critique but also a cultivation of critical sensitivity toward digital systems that increasingly mediate our everyday lives. Through this project, we hope to put forward a question; when identity does not remain stable and when datafication and recommendation systems are restructured, can we still have a real "self"? In an environment dominated by algorithms, how can individuals regain control over their own narrative? Our work does not provide an answer but instead tries to create a space for the audience to reflect.

Artist Statement

Our initial idea was that the internet has never truly been a private or personal space. Instead, it is a shared environment where people constantly interact and exchange information. In many ways, individuals do not really have secrets online because everything we do can leave traces. This idea became the foundation of our theme: a shared network world.

The concept was partly inspired by Jonas Lund's exhibition *We See in Every Direction*. In this project, multiple users browse the internet together in the same interface, showing that the internet is not an isolated experience but a collective environment. This made me think about how easily people can search for information about others online today. If someone knows your full name or address, it can often be surprisingly easy to find personal information about you. This idea inspired the creation of my first page, *Input or Trace*.

While developing this page, I encountered several technical challenges. This was my first time building a website using DOM manipulation instead of traditional HTML and CSS, so I reviewed the course materials to better understand how DOM could be used to construct the page. One early problem was that my images did not match the screen size correctly. I designed the page using a grid layout where each grid should display a full image, but when the browser window changed size the images became cropped or distorted. After trying many `dom.style` adjustments, I eventually modified the images themselves so they would better fit the layout.

While working on the *Input* page, I also noticed that I often created many DOM elements but they did not appear on the screen. By checking the developer tools (F12), I discovered that I had appended the elements to the wrong parent div. Although the code executed, the content was placed in the wrong container. Another issue involved the order of input and output. Sometimes when a user entered an answer, the next question appeared immediately, which made the interaction confusing. I reorganized the JavaScript logic so that questions appear sequentially and the answers are recorded in the log

window. If the user does not respond, the system generates answers from simulated users so the page continues producing content. This design reflects how digital systems constantly generate and record data traces.

The second page, Storage or Loss, was inspired by the concept of Dead Drops. It simulates how data is stored within network systems while older information may eventually be replaced or deleted. When files are uploaded, the system creates a folder that records the user's content. One problem I encountered was that files could still be moved after being dragged into the folder. I solved this by creating an overlay layer and controlling pointer events to lock the interaction once the file is placed. Another issue was organizing the files inside the folder. At first I used images alone, but it was difficult to identify the order of the files. I added `<p>` elements as file names and grouped them with the images so they move together and remain organized.

The third page was inspired by the location-based game Can You See Me Now?. The interface recreates a simplified map where simulated users move across the space. One of the first problems I encountered was that many dots did not appear correctly. I initially thought it was a CSS problem, but later realized the positions of the dots were not updating properly. Another challenge was managing different dot states such as normal dots, blinking dots, yellow targets, and red captured dots. I solved this by creating a JavaScript class to manage the behavior of each dot and using an animation loop to update their positions.

The fourth page, Stay With Me, was inspired by Jonas Lund's We See in Every Direction. In my version, when the user clicks an emoji, multiple cursors appear on the screen, representing other users entering the same space. As more cursors appear, the emoji is no longer alone. This interaction reflects how online platforms and AI systems collect user activity and place individuals within a shared digital environment.

The final page concludes the project. The Earth symbolizes how we all exist within the same internet environment, just as we share the same planet. When the user clicks the Earth, it merges and moves to the bottom-right corner, suggesting that data never truly disappears but remains somewhere within the system. The user can click the small Earth again to return to the main page, reinforcing the idea of a continuous and interconnected network.

My ideas were also influenced by the web project "This Website Will Self-Destruct." In that project, the content is generated collectively by users. If no new messages are posted for 24 hours, the entire website deletes itself. This concept highlights how the internet depends on user participation. Without users contributing content, there would be no data, and the network itself would lose its meaning as a shared environment.

References

Blast Theory. Can You See Me Now? (2003)
<https://www.blasttheory.co.uk/projects/can-you-see-me-now/>

Bartholl, Aram. Dead Drops (2010) <https://deaddrops.com/>

Lund, Jonas. *We See In Every Direction* (2013).
<https://jonaslund.com/works/we-see-in-every-direction/>

Bucher, Taina. "The Algorithmic Imaginary: Exploring the Ordinary Affects of Facebook Algorithms." *Information, Communication & Society*, 2017.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2016.1154086>

Maiberg, Emanuel. "This Website Will Self Destruct If You Stop Posting." *VICE*, April 21, 2020. <https://www.vice.com/en/article/this-website-will-self-destruct-if-you-stop-posting/>